

LegalConnect: Complete Beginner's Setup Guide

Welcome! This guide will walk you through the exact steps needed to set up and run the LegalConnect AI platform on your own Windows computer from scratch.

This application has three main pillars:

1. **The Database (PostgreSQL):** Where all the lawyer and user data is stored safely.
2. **The Backend (Python):** The "brain" that connects to the AI and talks to the database.
3. **The Frontend (React/Next.js):** The visual user interface that you click and interact with in your web browser.

Don't worry if you are new to programming! Just open your Command Prompt (or PowerShell) when instructed and follow these commands step-by-step.

Step 1: Install the Required Software

Before typing any code, you need to install three free foundational tools on your computer.

1. PostgreSQL (The Database)

- Go to the official PostgreSQL download page: [Download PostgreSQL for Windows](#).
- Download the installer for Windows x86-64 (version 16 or newer is fine).
- Run the installer. You can click "Next" through most of the default options, but **pay close attention to the Password screen**. It will ask you to create a password for the postgres superuser. **Write this password down!** You will need it later to connect your Python app to the database.
- Leave the port as 5432 (the default).

2. Python

- Download from [python.org](#).
- **CRITICAL STEP:** When you open the Python installer, look at the very bottom of the first window and **check the box that says "Add Python to PATH"** before clicking Install.

3. Node.js

- Download the "LTS" (Long Term Support) version from [nodejs.org](#).
- This allows you to run the Next.js frontend. You can just click "Next" through the default installer.

Step 2: Set Up the Python Backend

We will start by creating your project folder on your D:\ drive and setting up a secure "virtual environment" for your Python tools. A virtual environment keeps your project's files neatly isolated from the rest of your computer.

1. Create your main Project folder:

Open your **Command Prompt** and type these exact commands, pressing **Enter** after each one:

```
D:
mkdir Project
cd Project
```

(You are now inside D:\Project)

2. Create and Activate your Virtual Environment:

We will create a virtual environment (and backend folder) named Lawyer. Type this command:

```
python -m venv Lawyer
```

Now, **activate** it so you can use it:

```
Lawyer\Scripts\activate
```

(You should now see (Lawyer) appear at the very beginning of your command prompt line. This means your virtual environment is officially active!)

3. Install the Backend Tools:

With your virtual environment active, install the tools that power our server and database. Copy and paste these exact commands, pressing Enter after each:

```
pip install groq python-dotenv
pip install fastapi uvicorn pydantic
python -m pip install psycopg2-binary
```

Step 3: Set Up the React Frontend

Now we will create the visual user interface. We need to do this in your main Project folder, right next to your Lawyer folder.

1. Create the Next.js Application:

While still in your Command Prompt, make sure you are in D:\Project. If you are inside the Lawyer folder, type `cd ..` to go back. Then run this command:

```
npx create-next-app@latest legal-frontend
```

*(This triggers a setup wizard. It will ask you a series of questions like "Would you like to use TypeScript?" or "Would you like to use Tailwind CSS?". Just **press Enter** repeatedly to accept*

the default "Yes" answers for all of them).

2. Move into your new Frontend folder:

```
cd legal-frontend
```

(You are now inside D:\Project\legal-frontend)

3. Install the Frontend Tools:

Install the professional icons and the Firebase authentication system we use for user logins:

```
npm install lucide-react  
npm install firebase
```

Step 4: Connecting Your Secret Keys

For security reasons, API keys and database passwords are never saved directly in the code. You must create two hidden configuration files on your computer.

1. The Backend Keys:

Inside your Backend folder (D:\Project\Lawyer), create a new text file named exactly .env (don't forget the dot at the beginning!) and add your database URL and Groq API key:

```
GROQ_API_KEY=your_groq_api_key_here  
DATABASE_URL=postgresql://postgres:YOUR_PASSWORD_HERE@localhost:5432/legal_db
```

(Replace YOUR_PASSWORD_HERE with the password you created in Step 1!)

2. The Frontend Keys:

Inside your Frontend folder (D:\Project\legal-frontend), create a file named exactly .env.local and add your Firebase connection keys:

```
NEXT_PUBLIC_FIREBASE_API_KEY=your_api_key_here  
NEXT_PUBLIC_FIREBASE_AUTH_DOMAIN=your_project.firebaseio.com  
NEXT_PUBLIC_FIREBASE_PROJECT_ID=your_project_id  
NEXT_PUBLIC_FIREBASE_STORAGE_BUCKET=your_storage_bucket  
NEXT_PUBLIC_FIREBASE_MESSAGING_SENDER_ID=your_sender_id  
NEXT_PUBLIC_FIREBASE_APP_ID=your_app_id
```

Step 5: How to Run the App!

To see the app working, you need to start both the backend and the frontend at the same time.

You will need **two separate Command Prompt windows** open.

Terminal 1: Start the Backend Server

1. Open a new Command Prompt.
2. Navigate to your backend folder and activate your virtual environment:

```
D:  
cd Project  
Lawyer\Scripts\activate  
cd Lawyer
```

3. Start the Python server:
uvicorn main:app --reload

(This starts the backend on port 8000. Leave this window open and running!)

Terminal 2: Start the Frontend Interface

1. Open a second, completely new Command Prompt.
2. Navigate to your frontend folder:

```
D:  
cd Project\legal-frontend
```

3. Start the Next.js user interface:
npm run dev

(This starts the user interface on port 3000).

🚀 **You are done!** Open your web browser and go to **http://localhost:3000** to see your LegalConnect platform live!